

R6 Balanced Reflections

Pillar	Reflection	Difficulty	Level 1
Time Required	30-35 minutes	Group Size	4-10
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	R1 active	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Forced positivity in reflections, overemphasis on wins without examining struggles, or conversely, reflection sessions that become complaint sessions

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

The brain has a natural negativity bias: negative experiences are processed more deeply and remembered more vividly than positive ones. This served our ancestors well (remembering threats is survival-critical) but distorts workplace reflection. Without balance, reflections drift toward either forced positivity (suppressing the negative, which the brain knows is dishonest, producing cognitive dissonance) or negativity spirals (ruminating on problems, which amplifies cortisol without producing solutions).

Balanced reflection deliberately engages both circuits: the brain's reward system (dopamine) processes wins and progress, while the analytical prefrontal cortex processes challenges and extracts learning. Both are needed. A reflection practice that only celebrates or only critiques is neurologically incomplete.

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Balance Check (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Think about our team's reflection habits. When we debrief a project or discuss how something went, where does the conversation naturally go? Do we default to 'what went well' and skip the uncomfortable parts? Or do we go straight to problems and forget to acknowledge what worked? Neither pattern serves us."

Ask the team to self-assess: on a spectrum from "relentlessly positive" to "relentlessly critical," where does the team's default reflection pattern sit? Most teams discover they lean one way.

Phase 2: The 2:1 Practice (15 minutes)

Introduce the 2:1 ratio: for every constructive insight (something to change), identify two genuine positives (things that worked and should continue). Not forced positives. Genuine ones.

Apply it to a recent team project or week:

4. Each person writes down one thing that needs to change (be specific)
5. Each person writes down two things that genuinely worked (also specific, not "everyone did great")
6. Share round: each person reads all three. The group notices the balance.

FACILITATION NOTE

The positives must be as specific as the constructive insights. "The project went well" is not a positive in this context. "The way Sarah structured the timeline meant we caught the dependency issue two weeks early" is a positive. Specificity in positive reflection produces the same dopamine reward as receiving external recognition.

Phase 3: Embedding the Balance (5 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"From now on, whenever we debrief anything as a team, we use the 2:1 structure. Two specifics that worked, one specific to change. It takes 5 minutes and it prevents us from either whitewashing or catastrophising. Who's going to prompt this at our next debrief?"

Assign a specific person to prompt the 2:1 structure at the next team debrief. Rotate the role monthly.

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
R1: Micro-Reflection	The 2:1 balance can be built into R1's daily prompts.	R6 enhances R1
R4: Structured Reflection Templates	Template A (After Action Review) benefits from R6's balance approach.	Complementary
V2: Failure Stories	V2 focuses on what went wrong. R6 ensures the full picture is captured.	R6 complements V2
OP9: Recognition and Celebration	R6's specific positive reflections are a form of recognition. They complement OP9's recognition system.	Complementary